animal. Unfortunately, Pathans have been unfairly treated there. It's unfortunate – Karachi runs the country and churns Pakistan's economic engine.

But the city is also a proxy battleground. That old school-of-hard-knocks gives us Karachiwalas an edge, a special type of determination. If I were from Peshawar Cricket Club, I wouldn't be who I am. Javed Miandad wouldn't be the hustler that he was; Zaheer Abbas wouldn't be as cosmopolitan as he was; Moin Khan wouldn't be the street fighter he was; nor would Saeed Anwar be the slashing assassin with the bat.

Karachi gives you grit. It gives you fortitude. Most importantly, it gives you claws, because you need them to walk its rough streets and climb its high walls. That's why Karachi boys are smart. Despite the bad schools, shabby streets, the polluted water and the wave of crime and terror, Karachiites are survivors. Ironically, my fellow citizens are still the most professional compared to any other place in Pakistan. Other cities seem like villages compared to Karachi. We Karachiites have the best work ethic and, hands down, are the hardest-working people in the country. We're a true melting pot of the country: Biharis, Bengalis, UP-walas, Pakhtuns, Balochis, Punjabis, Siraiki-speakers, Gujaratis, Memons and the Sindhis. They all break their backs every day to make Pakistan tick. Too bad they have been offered cards of wrath by successive governments and political parties.

Since we're talking politics, might as well get off the political fence here. This might shock a few people but in my growing-up years, I was fine with the feared Mohajir Qaumi Movement (MQM). I know they are really controversial now, and were even involved in terrorism. However, the '90s changed the MQM and the MQM changed Karachi. They did a lot of good work, no doubt, in Pakistan's greatest city. They were and are the most organized party in Pakistani politics. But they have changed since then. They have hurt the city and the people that made them.

Political violence is unacceptable. It's no good. There's enough violence in Pakistan. And organized political violence is unacceptable, in my opinion, unless you're fighting for your own country, which I hope the MQM is not.

But Karachi can't get worse than it is at the moment. I'm hoping my city will bounce back. The onus, however, is on the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf to fix things. The Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) has run my adopted province, Sindh, but the ball is now in PTI's court to deliver and make change happen. If they want to make a political comeback, they will have to fix things, for sure, and not just get charity votes in the names of the slain Bhuttos. The electorate is increasingly aware and smarter than it looks.

Yes, this is all sounding political. It should. Every citizen has a political responsibility. And a right to express his or her own opinion.